

The trail to Rainbow Ranch

Cowboy story • 3-4 years old



Morning on the Wide Prairie

The sun rose soft and gold over Sunbeam Town. Cowgirl May tied her blue scarf. She patted her gentle horse. "Good morning, Button," she said. Button flicked his ears. Clip-clop, clip-clop.

May had a small wooden box in her saddlebag. It was an inheritance from Aunt Star. It belonged to Little Jo at Rainbow Ranch, far across the hills. "We will bring this with care," May said. "We ride with kind hearts." Clip-clop, clip-clop, went Button on the dusty road.

The prairie was wide and bright. Red rocks sat like big cookies. Cactus raised green arms. The sky was a big, calm blue. May smiled. "The West is wide," she said. "There is room for us all."

Across the Open Trail

They came to a long fence and a gate. The gate was closed. May took a breath. "We can do this," she said. She climbed down. She opened the gate. She led Button through. She closed the gate behind them. "We keep things tidy," May said. Button snorted. Clip-clop, clip-clop.

At the river, the water sang. It looked deep and quick. May touched the cool splash. "Slow and smart," she said. A baker with a flour cart waved. "Need help?" he asked. "Yes, please," said May. They found flat stones. May tied her rope to a strong stump. "Hold on," she said. Step by step, they crossed where the water was gentle. The baker shared warm bread. May shared sweet apples. "Thank you," they said together. "We all help on the trail."

Farther on, a herd of cows filled the path. A small calf stood on the wrong side of a log. "Easy now," May said. She sang a soft, low song. She made a slow circle with her rope. The calf blinked and stepped over the log. The rancher smiled.

“Thank you, ma’am,” he said. “We share the trail,” said May. “We all belong under the same big sky.”

A wind whooshed and made little dust swirls. May pulled up her scarf. “Slow and steady, Button,” she said. They waited by a kind, round rock. The wind passed. The world turned quiet again. Clip-clop, clip-clop.

Warm Welcome at Rainbow Ranch

Rainbow Ranch sat by green grass and tall cottonwood trees. Little Jo ran to the gate. “You came!” Jo said. May smiled. “I kept it safe,” she said. She opened the wooden box. Inside was a shiny star pin and a small letter. May read in a gentle voice. “Dear Jo, this star is yours. Share your light. Be brave. Be kind.”

Jo hugged May. “I will,” Jo said. The baker rolled in with a laugh. The rancher tipped his hat. They all sat on the porch. They shared cookies and milk. They sang a simple song. “Different hats, different trails, one big sky,” they sang.

The sun turned peach and pink. Button munched sweet hay. May stroked his nose. “We did it,” she whispered. The stars came out, calm and bright. The West felt safe and warm. And everyone rested with happy hearts.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What did Cowgirl May ride?

- A bicycle
- A horse
- A cow
- A car

2) What did May carry in her saddlebag?

- A toy
- A wooden box
- A blanket
- A book

3) Who helped May cross the river?

- A cow
- A baker
- A cat
- A dog

4) What did Little Jo receive from May?

- A hat
- A star pin
- A horse
- A cookie

Correct answers:

1) A horse 2) A wooden box 3) A baker 4) A star pin

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Inheritance: Something that is passed down from someone who has died, usually money or property.

Prairie: A large, flat area of grassland with few trees.

Gentle: Calm and kind; not rough or violent.

Rancher: A person who owns or works on a ranch, a large farm where animals are raised.

Cottonwood: A type of tree that has soft, fluffy seeds and is often found near rivers.

Calm: Peaceful and quiet; not excited or worried.